DECLINE OF THE MUGHAL EMPIRE & THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY

CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1761 → DECLINE AS A CONVERGING → SUCCESSION AND THE SAYYID → FOUR JAGIRDARI TERMS → THE JAGIRDARI FEEDBACK LOOP → THE INHERITED DECCAN BURDEN

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW ◆ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g4 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1761

CHRONOLOGY, 1707-1761 · AURANGZEB DIES; CONTESTED SUCCESSION OPENS THE CORE PERIOD · JAHANDAR FALLS; FARRUKHSIYAR RISES WITH SAYYID SUPPORT · FARRUKHSIYAR DEPOSED; REPEATED ENTHRONEMENTS EXPOSE KINGMAKING · SAYYIDS FALL · NIZAM ESTABLISHES DECCAN AUTONOMY · NADIR SHAH DEFEATS THE MUGHALS AND SACKS DELHI · ABDALI INVASIONS

1707 → Aurangzeb dies; contested succession opens the core period → 1712-13 → Jahandar falls; Farrukhsiyar rises with Sayyid support → 1719 → Farrukhsiyar deposed; repeated enthronements expose kingmaking → 1720 → Sayyids fall → 1724 → Nizam establishes Deccan autonomy

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- 1707 → Aurangzeb dies; contested succession opens the core period
- 1712-13 → Jahandar falls; Farrukhsiyar rises with Sayyid support
- 1719 → Farrukhsiyar deposed; repeated enthronements expose kingmaking

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 1720 → Sayyids fall
- 1724 → Nizam establishes Deccan autonomy
- 1739 → Nadir Shah defeats the Mughals and sacks Delhi

IMPACT / LIMIT

- 1748-61 → Abdali invasions
- 14 Jan 1761 → Third Battle of Panipat.
- MUST REMEMBER: Mughal decline was multi-causal: jagirdari stress, succession, war, regional power and fiscal-military change interacted.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: MUST REMEMBER: Mughal decline was multi-causal: jagirdari stress, succession, war, regional power and fiscal-military change interacted.

01

STAGE 01 DECLINE AS A CONVERGING SYSTEM

DECLINE AS A CONVERGING SYSTEM · SUCCESSION CONFLICT + WIZARAT COMPETITION + NOBLE FACTIONS · JAGIR SCARCITY + JAMA-HASIL GAP + SHORT-TERM EXTRACTION · ZAMINDAR RESISTANCE, PEASANT FLIGHT AND UNEVEN COLLECTION · DECCAN EXHAUSTION, WEAK CONTINGENTS AND FRONTIER SHOCKS · PROVINCIAL GOVERNORS CONVERT OFFICE INTO DURABLE AUTONOMY · NO STRAND ALONE EXPLAINS TIMING, REACH OR CONTINUITY.

POLITICAL → succession conflict + wizarat competition + noble factions

FISCAL → jagir scarcity + jama-hasil gap + short-term extraction → AGRARIAN → zamindar resistance, peasant flight and uneven collection → MILITARY → Deccan exhaustion, weak contingents and frontier shocks

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- POLITICAL → succession conflict + wizarat competition + noble factions
- FISCAL → jagir scarcity + jama-hasil gap + short-term extraction

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- AGRARIAN → zamindar resistance, peasant flight and uneven collection
- MILITARY → Deccan exhaustion, weak contingents and frontier shocks

DEBATE / LEGACY

- REGIONAL → provincial governors convert office into durable autonomy
- RULE → no strand alone explains timing, reach or continuity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → no strand alone explains timing, reach or continuity.

02

STAGE 02 SUCCESSION AND THE SAYYID WIZARAT

SUCCESSION AND THE SAYYID WIZARAT · BAHADUR SHAH I · WINS THE 1707 SUCCESSION BUT SETTLES NO FIRM RULE · JAHANDAR SHAH · ZULFIQAR KHAN'S PATRONAGE SHOWS WAZIR-CENTRED LEVERAGE · FARRUKHSIYAR 1713 · THRONE SECURED THROUGH THE SAYYID BROTHERS · THE SAME COALITION DEPOSES AND KILLS HIM

BAHADUR SHAH I → wins the 1707 succession but settles no firm rule → JAHANDAR SHAH → Zulfiqar Khan's patronage shows wazir-centred leverage → FARRUKHSIYAR 1713 → throne secured through the Sayyid Brothers → 1719 → the same coalition deposes and kills him → ABDULLAH / HUSSAIN ALI → office, army and patronage sustain kingmaking

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- BAHADUR SHAH I → wins the 1707 succession but settles no firm rule
- JAHANDAR SHAH → Zulfiqar Khan's patronage shows wazir-centred leverage

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- FARRUKHSIYAR 1713 → throne secured through the Sayyid Brothers
- 1719 → the same coalition deposes and kills him

IMPACT / LIMIT

- ABDULLAH / HUSSAIN ALI → office, army and patronage sustain kingmaking
- 1720 → rival nobles remove them; factional rule outlives the episode.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: 1720 → rival nobles remove them; factional rule outlives the episode.

03

STAGE 03 FOUR JAGIRDARI TERMS

FOUR JAGIRDARI TERMS · ASSESSED OR ESTIMATED REVENUE CLAIM ON PAPER · REVENUE ACTUALLY REALISED AFTER CONTROL, HARVEST AND COLLECTION · RESERVE POOL AVAILABLE FOR ASSIGNMENT · SHORTAGE OF SUFFICIENTLY PRproductive AND USABLE JAGIRS · A HIGH JAMA CAN CONCEAL A WEAK HASIL · JAGIR IS A TRANSFERABLE REVENUE ASSIGNMENT, NOT PRIVATE OWNERSHIP.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

JAMA → assessed or estimated revenue claim on paper

HASIL → revenue actually realised after control, harvest and collection

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

PAIBAQI → reserve pool available for assignment

BE-JAGIRI → shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs

DEBATE / LEGACY

MEASUREMENT → a high jama can conceal a weak hasil

TRAP → jagir is a transferable revenue assignment, not private ownership.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- JAMA → assessed or estimated revenue claim on paper
- HASIL → revenue actually realised after control, harvest and collection

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- PAIBAQI → reserve pool available for assignment
- BE-JAGIRI → shortage of sufficiently productive and usable jagirs

DEBATE / LEGACY

- MEASUREMENT → a high jama can conceal a weak hasil
- TRAP → jagir is a transferable revenue assignment, not private ownership.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → jagir is a transferable revenue assignment, not private ownership.

04

STAGE 04 THE JAGIRDARI FEEDBACK LOOP

THE JAGIRDARI FEEDBACK LOOP · MORE CLAIMANTS · WEAK PAIBAQI · PRESSURE FOR PRODUCTIVE ASSIGNMENTS · SHORT TENURE · POOR JAGIR · ASSIGNEE SEEKS RAPID EXTRACTION · LOCAL PRESSURE

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- MORE CLAIMANTS / WEAK PAIBAQI → pressure for productive assignments
- SHORT TENURE / POOR JAGIR → assignee seeks rapid extraction

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- LOCAL PRESSURE → zamindar resistance, evasion, debt, flight or negotiation
- LOWER HASIL → contingent maintenance and imperial service weaken

DEBATE / LEGACY

- MILITARY FAILURE / DISTURBANCE → collection becomes still harder
- RESULT → fiscal, agrarian and political strain reproduces itself.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → fiscal, agrarian and political strain reproduces itself.

05

STAGE 05 THE INHERITED DECCAN BURDEN

THE INHERITED DECCAN BURDEN · 1686-87 ANNEXATIONS · MORE TERRITORY, FORTS, ELITES AND PAPER REVENUE · 1687-1707 WAR · SIEGE, TRANSPORT, GARRISON AND REMOUNT COSTS ACCUMULATE · BUFFER REMOVAL · DIRECT CONFLICT WITH DISPERSED MARATHA NETWORKS EXPANDS · DISTURBED DISTRICTS

1686-87 ANNEXATIONS → more territory, forts, elites and paper revenue → 1687-1707 WAR → siege, transport, garrison and remount costs accumulate → BUFFER REMOVAL → direct conflict with dispersed Maratha networks expands → DISTURBED DISTRICTS → assessed jama outruns reliable hasil → POST-1707 INHERITANCE → claimant pressure and military obligations remain

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- 1686-87 ANNEXATIONS → more territory, forts, elites and paper revenue
- 1687-1707 WAR → siege, transport, garrison and remount costs accumulate

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- BUFFER REMOVAL → direct conflict with dispersed Maratha networks expands
- DISTURBED DISTRICTS → assessed jama outruns reliable hasil

DEBATE / LEGACY

- POST-1707 INHERITANCE → claimant pressure and military obligations remain
- VERDICT → Deccan war is a legacy mechanism, not the whole decline story.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → Deccan war is a legacy mechanism, not the whole decline story.

06

STAGE 06 FROM CENTRE TO REGION: A SPECTRUM

FROM CENTRE TO REGION · A SPECTRUM · DIRECT CENTRE · APPOINTMENT, REVENUE ORDER AND MILITARY COMMAND FROM DELHI · NEGOTIATED PROVINCE · GOVERNOR AND LOCAL ELITES BARGAIN WITHIN IMPERIAL FORMS · DE FACTO AUTONOMY · PROVINCIAL RULER CONTROLS REVENUE, ARMY AND SUCCESSION

DIRECT CENTRE → appointment, revenue order and military command from Delhi

NEGOTIATED PROVINCE → governor and local elites bargain within imperial forms → DE FACTO AUTONOMY → provincial ruler controls revenue, army and succession → FORMAL DEFERENCE → title, coin, khutba or confirmation may still invoke emperor

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- DIRECT CENTRE → appointment, revenue order and military command from Delhi
- NEGOTIATED PROVINCE → governor and local elites bargain within imperial forms

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- DE FACTO AUTONOMY → provincial ruler controls revenue, army and succession
- FORMAL DEFERENCE → title, coin, khutba or confirmation may still invoke emperor

DEBATE / LEGACY

- LOCAL POWER → zamindars and chiefs can cooperate, resist or become state-builders
- TRAP → autonomy is a process; it is not one simultaneous declaration.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → autonomy is a process; it is not one simultaneous declaration.

07

STAGE 07 BENGAL, AWADH AND HYDERABAD COMPARED

BENGAL, AWADH AND HYDERABAD COMPARED · MURSHID QULI KHAN STABILISES REVENUE AND LIMITS JAGIR DISRUPTION · SAADAT KHAN BUILDS THROUGH ACCOMMODATION WITH ZAMINDARS AND TALUQDARS · NIZAM-UL-MULK CONVERTS SUBEDARI AND MILITARY POWER AFTER 1724 · REVENUE, ARMY AND PATRONAGE BECOME REGIONALLY CONTROLLED · MUGHAL TITLES AND SYMBOLIC LEGITIMACY OFTEN REMAIN USEFUL · FISCAL SETTLEMENT, LOCAL ALLIANCE AND MILITARY CONVERSION VARY.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

BENGAL → Murshid Quli Khan stabilises revenue and limits jagir disruption

AWADH → Saadat Khan builds through accommodation with zamindars and taluqdars

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

HYDERABAD → Nizam-ul-Mulk converts subedari and military power after 1724

SHARED → revenue, army and patronage become regionally controlled

DEBATE / LEGACY

SHARED → Mughal titles and symbolic legitimacy often remain useful.

DIFFERENCE → fiscal settlement, local alliance and military conversion vary.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- BENGAL → Murshid Quli Khan stabilises revenue and limits jagir disruption
- AWADH → Saadat Khan builds through accommodation with zamindars and taluqdars

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- HYDERABAD → Nizam-ul-Mulk converts subedari and military power after 1724
- SHARED → revenue, army and patronage become regionally controlled

DEBATE / LEGACY

- SHARED → Mughal titles and symbolic legitimacy often remain useful
- DIFFERENCE → fiscal settlement, local alliance and military conversion vary.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DIFFERENCE → fiscal settlement, local alliance and military conversion vary.

08

STAGE 08 JATS, SIKHS AND MARATHAS: BOUNDED SNAPSHOT

JATS, SIKHS AND MARATHAS · BOUNDED SNAPSHOT · AGRARIAN-ZAMINDARI POWER CONSOLIDATES AROUND BHARATPUR · KHALSA, MISLS AND ARMED COMMUNITY FORMATION RESHAPE PUNJAB POLITICS · CHAUTH CLAIMS AND CONFEDERATE EXPANSION REACH MALWA AND THE · IMPERIAL WEAKENING OPENS SPACE, BUT EACH ROUTE HAS DISTINCT · SHIVAJI'S STATE DETAIL BELONGS TO TOPIC 23 · LATER CONFEDERACY AND COMPANY WARS REQUIRE THEIR PROPER OWNERS.

JATS → agrarian-zamindari power consolidates around Bharatpur

SIKHS → Khalsa, misls and armed community formation reshape Punjab politics → MARATHAS → chauth claims and confederate expansion reach Malwa and the north → COMMON → imperial weakening opens space, but each route has distinct institutions

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- JATS → agrarian-zamindari power consolidates around Bharatpur
- SIKHS → Khalsa, misls and armed community formation reshape Punjab politics

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- MARATHAS → chauth claims and confederate expansion reach Malwa and the north
- COMMON → imperial weakening opens space, but each route has distinct institutions

DEBATE / LEGACY

- BOUNDARY → Shivaji's state detail belongs to Topic 23
- BOUNDARY → later confederacy and Company wars require their proper owners.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: BOUNDARY → later confederacy and Company wars require their proper owners.

09

STAGE 09 NADIR SHAH, ABDALI AND PANIPAT

NADIR SHAH, ABDALI AND PANIPAT · NADIR SHAH 1739 · KARNAL DEFEAT EXPOSES WEAKNESS; DELHI LOSES TREASURE · SEVERE FISCAL AND PRESTIGE SHOCK ACCELERATES AN OLDER CRISIS · ABDALI 1748-61 · REPEATED INVASIONS KEEP THE NORTHWEST UNDER PRESSURE · PANIPAT 1761 · ABDALI COALITION DEFEATS SADASHIVRAO BHAU'S MARATHA FORCE

NADIR SHAH 1739 → Karnal defeat exposes weakness; Delhi loses treasure → EFFECT → severe fiscal and prestige shock accelerates an older crisis → ABDALI 1748-61 → repeated invasions keep the northwest under pressure → PANIPAT 1761 → Abdali coalition defeats Sadashivrao Bhau's Maratha force → LIMIT → Panipat checks northern expansion but does not end Maratha power

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- NADIR SHAH 1739 → Karnal defeat exposes weakness; Delhi loses treasure
- EFFECT → severe fiscal and prestige shock accelerates an older crisis
- ABDALI 1748-61 → repeated invasions keep the northwest under pressure

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- PANIPAT 1761 → Abdali coalition defeats Sadashivrao Bhau's Maratha force
- LIMIT → Panipat checks northern expansion but does not end Maratha power
- TRAP → neither 1739 nor 1761 alone makes later British rule inevitable.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- CLOSE DISTINCTION: Hyderabad, Awadh and Bengal were successor states that adapted Mughal institutions, not mere evidence of anarchy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → neither 1739 nor 1761 alone makes later British rule inevitable.

10

STAGE 10 REGIONAL ECONOMIC AND CULTURAL CONTINUITY

REGIONAL ECONOMIC AND CULTURAL CONTINUITY · POLITICAL CENTRE CONTRACTS · PATRONAGE AND RESOURCES SHIFT REGIONALLY · HOUSES SUCH AS JAGAT SETH REMAIN INFLUENTIAL · ROUTES AND PRODUCTION PERSIST UNEVENLY ACROSS REGIONS · COURTS SUPPORT ART, LITERATURE AND ARCHITECTURE · WARFARE, EXTRACTION AND LOCAL LOSSES REMAIN REAL · REGIONAL REORGANISATION, NOT UNIFORM ECONOMIC-CULTURAL COLLAPSE.

POLITICAL CENTRE CONTRACTS → patronage and resources shift regionally

BANKERS / CREDIT → houses such as Jagat Seth remain influential → TRADE / CRAFT → routes and production persist unevenly across regions → AWADH / HYDERABAD / BENGAL → courts support art, literature and architecture

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- POLITICAL CENTRE CONTRACTS → patronage and resources shift regionally
- BANKERS / CREDIT → houses such as Jagat Seth remain influential
- TRADE / CRAFT → routes and production persist unevenly across regions

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- AWADH / HYDERABAD / BENGAL → courts support art, literature and architecture
- QUALIFY → warfare, extraction and local losses remain real
- VERDICT → regional reorganisation, not uniform economic-cultural collapse.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- EVIDENCE LIMIT: The eighteenth century is a transition with regional growth and new competition, not a teleological prelude to British rule.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — EVIDENCE LIMIT: The eighteenth century is a transition with regional growth and new competition, not a teleological prelude to British rule.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The eighteenth century is a transition with regional growth and new competition, not a teleological prelude to British rule.

11

STAGE 11 NON-INEVITABILITY AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE

NON-INEVITABILITY AND FINAL ANSWER SPINE · DECLINE IS DEVOLUTION AND CONVERGING STRAIN, NOT INSTANT DISAPPEARANCE · JAGIRDARI LOOP · REGIONAL AUTONOMY · EXTERNAL SHOCKS · HYDERABAD BY DISTINCT MECHANISM · POLITICAL FRAGMENTATION WITH ECONOMIC-CULTURAL CONTINUITY · RULER-ONLY BLAME, ONE-CAUSE CRISIS AND AUTOMATIC COLONIAL SUCCESSION

OPEN → decline is devolution and converging strain, not instant disappearance → TRACE → succession → jagirdari loop → regional autonomy → external shocks → COMPARE → Bengal / Awadh / Hyderabad by distinct mechanism → BALANCE → political fragmentation with economic-cultural continuity → REJECT → ruler-only blame, one-cause crisis and automatic colonial succession

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- OPEN → decline is devolution and converging strain, not instant disappearance
- TRACE → succession → jagirdari loop → regional autonomy → external shocks

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- COMPARE → Bengal / Awadh / Hyderabad by distinct mechanism
- BALANCE → political fragmentation with economic-cultural continuity

DEBATE / LEGACY

- REJECT → ruler-only blame, one-cause crisis and automatic colonial succession
- CLOSE → 1707-61 created opportunities; later outcomes remained contingent.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → 1707-61 created opportunities; later outcomes remained contingent.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · ADVANCED EVIDENCE NOTEBOOK · TWENTY-FOUR SOURCE-TO-ARGUMENT LABS · EVIDENCE AND ANSWER-WRITING DRILLS · DECLINE OF THE MUGHAL EMPIRE & THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY · 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA · 2. KEY CLASSIFICATION · 3. STUDY LINKS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Advanced evidence notebook: twenty-four source-to-argument labs
- Evidence and answer-writing drills
- Decline of the Mughal Empire & the Eighteenth Century — ADVANCED
- Mini-timeline

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data
- 3. Study links
- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

LEGACY / NUANCE

- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link
- 7. Mains angles
- + Historiography ladder (PYQ-gap)

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels